

French election campaign will be buffeted by multiple crises this week

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Short-term trajectory:

Long-term trajectory:

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A series of crises will engulf France this week, with potential implications for the presidential campaign and intensifying market pressure on the country's fragile public finances; for now, Eurasia Group continues to assign a 40% probability to the 2027 budget passing and a 40% probability to the centrist former Prime Minister Edouard Philippe winning the 2 May run-off.

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Several days of high-school protests will converge on Tuesday, 6 October with nationwide marches by state employees against budget cuts, potentially producing violent scenes across major French cities.

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Presidential front-runner Marine Le Pen will provide further detail on her fiscal agenda while confronting allegations of antisemitism against her number two, Jordan Bardella; the controversy comes as her most likely centrist rival, Philippe, is slowly recovering from a run of weak opinion polls.

The government's efforts to reassure markets about France's public finances will continue to be shaken by violent protests this week. The protests—which the government believes were partially fomented by the hard left—are likely to merge with street marches against budget cuts by public sector unions on 6 October. The government also fears that student anger about the state of public schools will combine with wider public fury about the high cost of fuel and create an insurrectionary atmosphere reminiscent of the Yellow Vest protests of 2018-9. A nationwide protest against pump prices is due on 17 October.

Despite increasing investor concerns about France's political and social stability, a "runoff of the extremes" between Le Pen and Jean-Luc Melenchon remains unlikely. Le Pen looks certain to top the first round poll but Melenchon is unlikely to take the second place (only a 10% probability). Melenchon has higher negative ratings—in the mid-70s—than any other senior French politician. Anti-Melenchon feeling on the moderate left has also deepened in recent days after he expressed support, later withdrawn, for the more violent aspects of the school protests. Moreover, a new survey last week by Ifop suggested that Melenchon's rise in the polls has stalled.

A poll for Le Figaro gave second place to Philippe—21% of the round one vote, 12 points behind Le Pen but five points ahead of Melenchon. Philippe's campaign has, admittedly, been cautious and unexciting. Amid a national mood of anger and hunger for change, he has created no strong identity for his candidacy other than "safe pair of hands".

Nonetheless, senior Philippe allies remain convinced that this will prove a winning strategy by next spring, as fear of Melenchon and doubts about the competence and economic platform of Le Pen eventually persuade a significant chunk of the electorate to seek a "reformist but safe" option.

At this stage of the campaign, Philippe's strategy has been to win the unofficial but critical "primary of the centre". There are some early signs that this plan is working. All opinion polls show him to be more popular in round one—and more capable of challenging Le Pen in round two—than his centrist rival Gabriel Attal or the leader of the centre-right Les Républicains, Bruno Retailleau.

Unrest on the streets and unease in the financial markets will, Philippe's strategists believe, help him by alarming two key swing electorates: the over 65's and the moderately well-off. Le Pen's strategists take a similar view. Continued sharp market movements against France's debt load could hurt Le Pen by encouraging some voters to look for "safety" rather than radical change.

Le Pen's keynote economic speech on 6 October is critical. She will give details of her plans to cut €125 billion from government spending over the five years of the next presidential term (see Eurasia Group practice letter— France: Le Pen will aim to address market fears , 2 October 2026). If she fails to go much beyond her previous vague plans to find the money—mostly by reducing fraud, public spending on migrants and illegally withholding France's payments to the EU—doubts about her ability to face up to the country's deepening fiscal crisis will likely grow.

Le Pen will also address next year's budget, which faces a hostile reception by a splintered National Assembly. Le Pen may not commit herself but we believe that she is ready to prevent a crisis, either by abstaining in a normal vote or standing aside from a left-wing censure motion (see Eurasia Group Note—French budget threatens yet another government , 22 September 2026).

Le Pen is also struggling to contain a crisis within her own National Rally party. This could threaten to unravel the progress she has made in the last 16 years towards "de-demonising" her father's far right movement. Bardella has been accused by the left-leaning investigative website Mediapart of making antisemitic statements when he was a young party member 14 years ago. Bardella could have killed the controversy by disassociating himself from his 17-year old self. He chose to say the messages were fakes. If they prove to be genuine, he will be shown to have lied on a subject which is central to his and Le Pen's claims to have cleaned up a once avowedly antisemitic and racist party.

For now, it remains our basecase that Le Pen will win the first round of the election on 18 April and that her opponent in the runoff will be Philippe. Overall, we give a 35% probability of a Le Pen victory and a 40% chance to Philippe on 2 May.

Happy to discuss,

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